happen for yourself. All you can do is concentrate on playing for your club and hope that you catch the eye of the right person. As a teenager, I had enough on my plate trying to establish myself at United. That first Double-winning season, though, brought all of us into the limelight—and into the reckoning as far as England was concerned. When it happened for me, it all came quicker than I could have imagined, and was a bigger thrill than I'd ever let myself dream it might be. Almost overnight, it seemed I went from being a promising player at my club to being a regular part of the England team challenging for a place in the 1998 World Cup finals in France.

Terry Venables had left the England coaching job straight after Euro 96. I'd already met his replacement, Glenn Hoddle, during the Under-21 Toulon Tournament at the end of the 1995/96 season. We knew Glenn was going to be the next England manager, so it was quite exciting that he came out to France to watch a couple of games and introduce himself to us. As a player, Glenn had been a hero of mine. I'd always admired not just his technical ability—he really was a man who could hit a Hollywood pass—but also his whole approach to the game. I even got him to sign my England shirt after one of the matches. I'm not sure if the Toulon tournament was the first time he'd watched me, but I had a good game the night he showed up. He didn't say anything to me but, going into the new season, the possibility of playing for the full England side was in the back of my mind for the first time.

There aren't many players who get an England call-up completely out of the blue. New caps very rarely come as a complete surprise. I was lucky: I was playing in a successful United team and, against Wimbledon, had scored the kind of goal that brings you to people's attention. Obviously, an England coach knows all about you anyway, but my start to the season meant there was a lot of speculation in the press, talking about me as a future England player who might be ready for his chance. There was a World Cup qualifier, away to Moldova, in September. I should have spoken to Gary Neville about it, but I think there was a bit of rivalry there: he was already in the England team and I wasn't. Most players have a story about a dramatic phone call or their club manager pulling them aside at the training ground to tell them the news. I found out I'd made the England squad while sitting on the sofa at my mum and dad's. Mum and I had been watching the television, when the details came up. As soon as I saw the name Beckham on the list of players Glenn Hoddle had chosen for his first game in charge, I jumped off the sofa. I surprised myself how excited I was. Mum and I hugged, laughing out loud, and then I was on the phone to my dad who was at work. For once, I think he was completely lost for words. He was proud, though. As proud as I was to be given my chance.